

I. Spyware And Adware

Source:

“Spyware: The first thing you need to know is that you probably have it”
available at

ww2.websense.com/docs/WhitePapers/Spywareyouprobablyhaveit.pdf

Spyware—software installed on a computer usually without the user’s knowledge or permission—along with adware and other similar software, gathers information and sends it back to the advertiser who initiated it or other interested parties. Spyware can collect and transmit information such as keystrokes, Web surfing habits, passwords, e-mail addresses, and other sensitive information you may not want to share outside your organisation. Spyware also misuses system resources and bandwidth as it tracks and transmits information. More seriously, spyware can also pose grave security, confidentiality, and compliance risks.

Spyware programs collect data on users and their computing behaviours and then transmit that information back to the spyware host server. These programs can also monitor keystrokes, scan files on hard drives, secretly install other programs, and even make changes to default computer settings. Spyware is often acquired surreptitiously when users download a ‘real’ application or file, visit certain Web sites, or click on a deceptive pop-up window. Unlike spyware, which is acquired without user knowledge or approval, adware is installed with permission, usually after the user agrees to the terms of a long and confusing End User License Agreement (EULA). These more benign programs also collect information about users or user habits, but typically use it to tailor future pop-up advertisements to users’ preferences for marketing purposes. These programs cause performance problems and use expensive computing resources—processing power, drive space, and bandwidth. They can also cause software conflicts with legitimate programs and affect employee productivity. Of most concern to organisations, however, is the fact that spyware compromises information security and consumes valuable IT Help Desk resources. Organisations whose investors and clients rely on them to safeguard personal, medical, and financial information need a